

CITY HELPERS

Digital Marketing Hackathon — One-Week Deep-Dive Project

Project Objective

City Helpers is looking for a practical digital marketing strategy to help generate **real customers and dispatch orders in the Toronto/GTA market**.

The current business model allows a customer to pay a **\$9.99 dispatch fee** to submit a request for help. City Helpers then connects the customer with potential local helpers.

The goal of this project is **not to create a broad marketing plan covering everything**.

Instead, we want the team to conduct a deep dive into the areas that are most likely to determine whether City Helpers can acquire customers efficiently and scale.

The four key questions are:

1. **Who should City Helpers target first?**
2. **Where can we reach those customers?**
3. **What should we say to get them to take action?**
4. **How do we turn website visitors into paying dispatch customers?**

PRIORITY 1 — Identify the Best Initial Customers

Objective

Determine which customer groups in the Toronto/GTA area should be the primary focus of City Helpers' initial marketing efforts.

City Helpers has three broad markets:

Homeowners / Seniors / Families

People who need help with things such as:

- Yard work

- Cleaning
- Moving/lifting
- Garage or household projects
- Small repairs
- Errands
- Other short-term chores

Businesses

Businesses that occasionally need additional help with:

- Labour
- Moving
- Landscaping
- Cleaning
- Warehousing
- Events
- Construction
- Other short-term projects

Workers

- Workers go to the website to register and get vetted
- University & college students.
- Underemployed
- Gig workers
- Anyone who wants to earn extra money.

Student Assignment

Research these markets and determine:

- Who has the strongest potential need?
- What problems are they trying to solve?
- How frequently might they need help?
- What alternatives do they currently use?
- How do they search for help?
- What would make them trust City Helpers?
- Which customer segments appear most practical to test first?

Develop **3–5 specific customer profiles**.

For each profile identify:

Who they are → What problem they have → Where they look for help → What would make them use City Helpers.

PRIORITY 2 — Customer Acquisition Research

Objective

Determine **where City Helpers should spend its marketing effort to find customers.**

The team should investigate the major potential channels rather than assuming that every social-media platform is equally useful.

Research:

Google/Search

What are people searching for when they need help?

Examples:

- Help around the house Toronto
- Moving help Toronto
- Yard work Toronto
- Lawn help Toronto
- Senior home help Toronto
- Cleaning help Toronto
- Handyman Toronto
- Temporary labour Toronto
- Extra workers Toronto

Develop a list of the most relevant search terms and group them according to customer intent.

Social Media

Investigate:

- Facebook
- Instagram
- LinkedIn
- YouTube
- Reddit
- Nextdoor/local community groups

Determine:

Which platforms are likely to reach homeowners and which are likely to reach businesses?

Paid Advertising

Research what types of advertising City Helpers should test.

For example:

- Google Search advertising
- Facebook/Instagram advertising
- LinkedIn advertising

The students should recommend **which channels should be tested first and why.**

Do not simply say:

"City Helpers should advertise on Facebook, Instagram, Google and LinkedIn."

Explain the reasoning and propose a test.

PRIORITY 3 — The City Helpers Marketing Message

Objective

Determine what City Helpers should actually say to potential customers.

The team should investigate how competitors and alternative services describe themselves.

Then develop several possible City Helpers positioning statements.

For example:

Problem-focused

Have a job you can't do yourself? Find local help through City Helpers.

Convenience-focused

Need an extra pair of hands? City Helpers connects you with local helpers for short-term jobs.

Business-focused

Need extra help for a short-term project? Find local workers through City Helpers.

These are only examples.

The students should conduct research and develop their own alternatives.

Test different approaches

The team should create sample:

- Google advertisements
- Facebook/Instagram advertisements
- Business advertisements
- Social-media posts
- Short video concepts

Each should answer:

Who is this for?

What problem does it solve?

Why City Helpers?

What should the customer do next?

PRIORITY 4 — Website Conversion

Objective

This is one of the most important parts of the project.

A marketing campaign is not useful if it sends people to a website and they don't understand what to do.

The students should conduct a **customer journey audit of CityHelpers.ca**.

Imagine that you have never heard of City Helpers.

Within the first few seconds, can you understand:

- What City Helpers is?

- Who it is for?
- What types of jobs can be requested?
- How much does it cost?
- How does the process work?
- What happens after I submit a request?
- Who performs the work?
- Why should I trust the service?
- What do I do next?

Students should identify:

Anything that could prevent a visitor from becoming a \$9.99 dispatch customer.

Then recommend specific changes.

For example:

- Homepage messaging
- Calls to action
- Request-help button
- Explanation of the \$9.99 dispatch
- How-it-works section
- Trust elements
- Customer testimonials
- Service categories
- Landing pages
- Mobile experience
- Checkout/request process

The students should prioritize their recommendations as:

HIGH PRIORITY

Changes that could directly affect customer conversion.

MEDIUM PRIORITY

Changes that could improve the customer experience.

LOW PRIORITY

Nice-to-have improvements that can wait.

THE MOST IMPORTANT PART — BUILD A CUSTOMER ACQUISITION MODEL

At the end of the week, I want the students to connect the four areas together.

For example:

Target Customer



Marketing Channel



Advertisement / Message



CityHelpers.ca



Customer Request



\$9.99 Dispatch

The students should develop several possible customer acquisition funnels.

For each funnel, estimate:

- Potential audience
- Advertising cost
- Expected website traffic
- Expected conversion rate
- Estimated dispatches
- Estimated customer acquisition cost

These are estimates, not guarantees.

Clearly identify the assumptions behind the calculations.

WHAT WE ARE NOT ASKING YOU TO DO

Because this is only a one-week project, **do not spend significant time on:**

- Creating a huge social-media calendar
- Designing dozens of posts
- Managing social-media accounts
- Developing a complete SEO program
- Creating hundreds of keywords
- Developing a full branding strategy
- Designing a complete website
- Building the entire advertising campaign
- Researching every possible Canadian market
- Trying to solve every City Helpers business problem

Those can be addressed later.

Your job is to determine **where City Helpers should focus first.**

FIVE-DAY WORK PLAN

DAY 1 — CUSTOMER

Research the Toronto/GTA market.

Identify:

- Most promising customer segments
- Customer problems
- Existing alternatives
- Customer behaviour
- 3–5 customer profiles

End-of-day question:

Who should City Helpers try to acquire first?

DAY 2 — ACQUISITION

Research:

- Google/search behaviour
- Social platforms
- Paid advertising
- Competitors
- Local online communities

Determine where potential customers can realistically be reached.

End-of-day question:

Where should City Helpers look for these customers?

DAY 3 — MESSAGE

Develop and test different marketing approaches.

Create sample:

- Google ads
- Facebook/Instagram ads
- Business ads
- Social posts
- Short video concepts

End-of-day question:

What should City Helpers say to make someone interested enough to click?

DAY 4 — CONVERSION

Conduct a detailed review of CityHelpers.ca.

Map the customer journey:

Advertisement → Website → Understanding → Trust → \$9.99 payment → Request submitted

Identify anything that could cause a customer to abandon the process.

End-of-day question:

What needs to change to turn more visitors into dispatch customers?

DAY 5 — PUT IT ALL TOGETHER

Build the final customer acquisition strategy.

The final presentation should show:

1. WHO

Who should City Helpers target?

2. WHERE

Where should we reach them?

3. WHAT

What should we say?

4. CONVERSION

What needs to happen on the website?

5. TEST

What should City Helpers test first?

6. MEASURE

What numbers should we track?

FINAL PRESENTATION

The final presentation should be approximately **15–20 minutes**.

It should answer one central question:

"If City Helpers gave us a marketing budget tomorrow, how would we use the first 90 days to find out whether we can generate customers and dispatch orders in Toronto?"

The final presentation should include:

Section 1 — Target Customer

Who should we target and why?

Section 2 — Customer Problem

What problem are we solving?

Section 3 — Acquisition Channels

Where should we find these customers?

Section 4 — Marketing Message

What should we say?

Section 5 — Website Conversion

What should change on CityHelpers.ca?

Section 6 — Customer Acquisition Funnel

Show the complete journey from advertisement to dispatch.

Section 7 — 90-Day Test Plan

What should City Helpers test first, second and third?

Section 8 — Measurement

What numbers should City Helpers track?

THE MOST IMPORTANT RULE

Don't tell us what you think we want to hear.

We want your research and your reasoning.

If you believe a particular advertising channel could work, explain why.

If you are uncertain, explain what experiment could determine whether it works.

If you think something City Helpers is currently doing should change, explain why.

The objective isn't to produce a beautiful marketing report.

The objective is to give City Helpers a **practical customer-acquisition strategy that can actually be tested after the hackathon.**

Final Question

At the end of your presentation, answer:

"If you were running City Helpers' marketing starting Monday morning, what are the first five things you would do?"